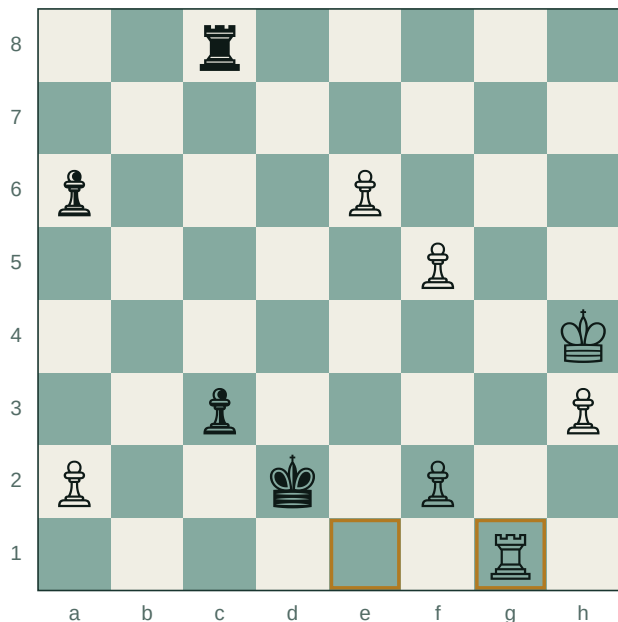


Rook-ending tactics: Black, move 53

Rook-ending tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 53.Rg1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

53...Rh8+ 54. Kg4 Rg8+

53...Rh8+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **54.Kg4**.

54...Rg8+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here.

At the end, nominal material is White 10 / Black 7 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from -3 to -3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A routine rook placement can miss a skewer or promotion with check. Let concrete tactics override a guideline when they conflict.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Rook endings combine pawn races with checks, cutoffs, and promotion tactics. Activity is vital, but the exact move order often decides whether a pawn can advance safely.

HOW TO LOOK

Check the kings' exposure, the rooks' checking distance, and the passed pawns. Calculate forcing checks before applying a general rook-ending rule.

The defending king is on h4. Geometrically undefended: rook on g1. Check for tactical protection.